

[Blog Post](#)[Plotting & Planning](#)

The Hero's Journey: A Story Structure as Old as Time

The Hero's Journey offers a powerful framework for creating quest-based stories emphasizing self-transformation.

by [The Campfire Team](#)



18 Minute Read

Holding out for a hero to take your story to the next level?

[^ Back to Top](#)

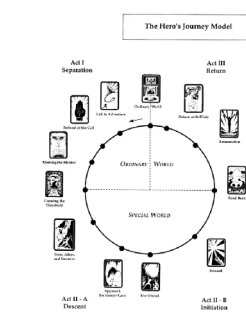
Joseph Campbell, this [narrative framework](#) packs mythic storytelling into a series of steps across three acts, each representing a crucial phase in a character's transformative journey.

Challenge. Growth. Triumph.

Whether you're penning a novel, screenplay, or video game, The Hero's Journey is [a tried-and-tested blueprint for crafting epic stories](#) that transcend time and culture. Let's explore the steps together and kickstart your next masterpiece.

What is the Hero's Journey?

The Hero's Journey is a famous template for storytelling, mapping a hero's adventurous quest through trials and tribulations to ultimate transformation.



A portrait of Joseph Campbell (©Joseph Campbell Archives and Library); Christopher Vogler's model of the Hero's Journey from *Myths and Movies* (1999) by Stuart Voytilla.

What are the Origins of the Hero's Journey?

[*Hero with a Thousand Faces*](#), where he introduces the concept of the "monomyth."

A comparative mythologist by trade, Campbell studied myths from cultures around the world and identified a common pattern in their narratives. He proposed that all mythic narratives are variations of a single, universal story, structured around a hero's adventure, trials, and eventual triumph.

His work unveiled the archetypal hero's path as a mirror to humanity's commonly shared experiences and aspirations. It was subsequently named one of the [All-Time 100 Nonfiction Books](#) by *TIME* in 2011.



Maureen Murdock, a student of Campbell's, challenged his popular framework with the introduction of the [Heroine's Journey](#) in 1990. Murdock cited that the Hero's Journey didn't account for the female experience.

How are the Hero's and Heroine's Journeys Different?

While both the Hero's and Heroine's Journeys share the theme of transformation, they diverge in their focus and execution.

The Hero's Journey, as outlined by Campbell, emphasizes external challenges and a quest for physical or metaphorical treasures. In contrast,

reconciliation, emotional growth, and the path to self-actualization.

In short, heroes seek to conquer the world, while heroines seek to transform their own lives; but...

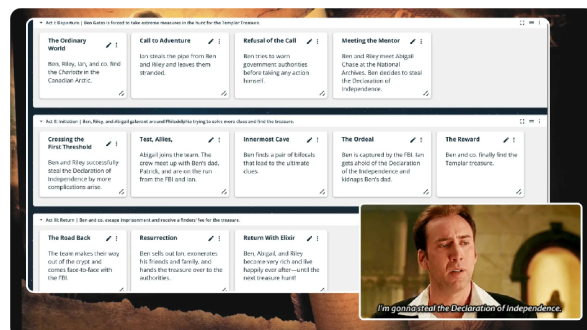


Today, the Hero's and Heroine's Journeys transcend gender. Either one can be applied to any character, regardless of gender identity ([just look at Katniss Everdeen](#)).

Twelve Steps of the Hero's Journey

So influential was Campbell's monomyth theory that it's been used as the basis for some of the largest franchises of our generation: *The Lord of the Rings*, *Harry Potter*...and George Lucas even [cited it as a direct influence](#) on *Star Wars*.

There are, in fact, several variations of the Hero's Journey, which we discuss further below. But for this breakdown, we'll use the twelve-step version outlined by Christopher Vogler in his book, *The Writer's Journey* (seemingly now out of print, unfortunately).



Motion Picture Studios) as an example of the method.

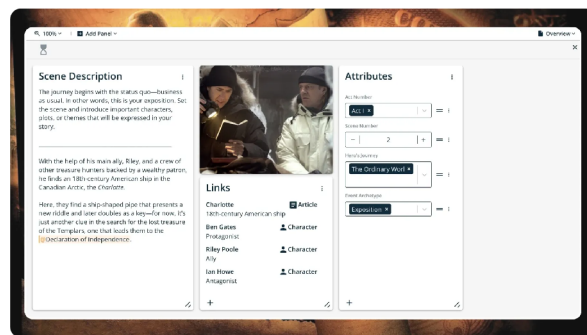
You probably already know the above stories pretty well so we'll unpack the twelve steps of the Hero's Journey using Ben Gates' journey in *National Treasure* as a case study—because what is more heroic than saving the Declaration of Independence from a bunch of goons?

Ye be warned: Spoilers ahead!

Act One: Departure

Step 1. The Ordinary World

The journey begins with the status quo—business as usual. We meet the hero and are introduced to the Known World they live in. In other words, this is your exposition, the starting stuff that establishes the story to come.



An event card in Campfire's Timeline Module showing The Ordinary World step of the Hero's Journey in *National Treasure* (2004, ©Walt Disney Motion Picture Studios).

National Treasure begins *in media res* (preceded only by a short prologue), where we are given key information that introduces us to Ben Gates' world, who

he's doing it (restoring his family's name).

With the help of his main ally, Riley, and a crew of other treasure hunters backed by a wealthy patron, he finds an 18th-century American ship in the Canadian Arctic, the *Charlotte*. Here, they find a ship-shaped pipe that presents a new riddle and later doubles as a key—for now, it's just another clue in the search for the lost treasure of the Templars, one that leads them to the Declaration of Independence.

Step 2. The Call to Adventure

The inciting incident takes place and the hero is called to act upon it. While they're still firmly in the Known World, the story kicks off and leaves the hero feeling out of balance. In other words, they are placed at a crossroads.

Ian (the wealthy patron of the *Charlotte* operation) steals the pipe from Ben and Riley and leaves them stranded. This is a key moment: Ian becomes the villain, Ben has now sufficiently lost his funding for this expedition, and if he decides to pursue the chase, he'll be up against extreme odds.

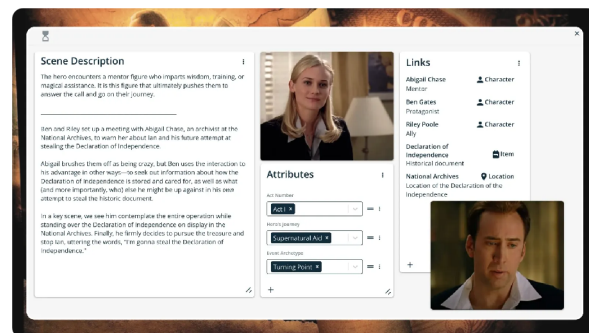
Step 3. Refusal of the Call

The hero hesitates and instead refuses their call to action. Following the call would mean making a conscious decision to break away from the status quo. Ahead lies danger, risk, and the unknown; but here and now, the hero is still in the safety and comfort of what they know.

action, he decides to try and warn the authorities: the FBI, Homeland Security, and the staff of the National Archives, where the Declaration of Independence is housed and monitored. Nobody will listen to him, and his family's notoriety doesn't help matters.

Step 4. Meeting the Mentor

The protagonist receives knowledge or motivation from a powerful or influential figure. This is a tactical move on the hero's part—remember that it was only the previous step in which they debated whether or not to jump headfirst into the unknown. By Meeting the Mentor, they can gain new information or insight, and better equip themselves for the journey they might to embark on.



An event card in Campfire's Timeline Module showing the Meeting the Mentor step of the Hero's Journey in *National Treasure* (2004, ©Walt Disney Motion Picture Studios).

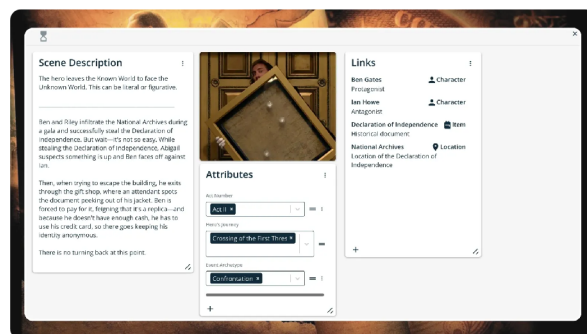
Abigail, an archivist at the National Archives, brushes Ben and Riley off as being crazy, but Ben uses the interaction to his advantage in other ways—to seek out information about how the Declaration of Independence is stored and cared for, as well as what (and more

In a key scene, we see him contemplate the entire operation while standing over the glass-encased Declaration of Independence. Finally, he firmly decides to pursue the treasure and stop Ian, uttering the famous line, "I'm gonna steal the Declaration of Independence."

Act Two: Initiation

Step 5. Crossing the Threshold

The hero leaves the Known World to face the Unknown World. They are fully committed to the journey, with no way to turn back now. There may be a confrontation of some sort, and the stakes will be raised.



An event card in Campfire's Timeline Module showing the Crossing the Threshold step of the Hero's Journey in *National Treasure* (2004, ©Walt Disney Motion Picture Studios).

Ben and Riley infiltrate the National Archives during a gala and successfully steal the Declaration of Independence. But wait—it's not so easy. While stealing the Declaration of Independence, Abigail suspects something is up and Ben faces off against Ian.

attendant spots the document peeking out of his jacket. He is forced to pay for it, feigning that it's a replica—and because he doesn't have enough cash, he has to use his credit card, so there goes keeping his identity anonymous.

The game is afoot.

Step 6. Tests, Allies, Enemies

The hero explores the Unknown World. Now that they have firmly crossed the threshold from the Known World, the hero will face new challenges and possibly meet new enemies. They'll have to call upon their allies, new and old, in order to keep moving forward.

Abigail reluctantly joins the team under the agreement that she'll help handle the Declaration of Independence, given her background in document archiving and restoration. Ben and co. seek the aid of Ben's father, Patrick Gates, whom Ben has a strained relationship with thanks to years of failed treasure hunting that has created a rift between grandfather, father, and son. Finally, they travel around Philadelphia deciphering clues while avoiding both Ian *and* the FBI.

Step 7. Approach the Innermost Cave

The hero nears the goal of their quest, the reason they crossed the threshold in the first place. Here, they could be making plans, having new revelations, or gaining new skills. To put it in other

Ben uncovers a pivotal clue—or rather, he finds an essential item—a pair of bifocals with interchangeable lenses made by Benjamin Franklin. It is revealed that by switching through the various lenses, different messages will be revealed on the back of the Declaration of Independence. He's forced to split from Abigail and Riley, but Ben has never been closer to the treasure.

Step 8. The Ordeal

The hero faces a dire situation that changes how they view the world. All threads of the story come together at this pinnacle, the central crisis from which the hero will emerge unscathed or otherwise. The stakes will be at their absolute highest here.

Vogler details that in this stage, the hero will experience a "death," though it need not be literal. In your story, this could signify the end of something and the beginning of another, which could itself be figurative or literal. For example, a certain relationship could come to an end, or it could mean someone "stuck in their ways" opens up to a new perspective.

In *National Treasure*, The FBI captures Ben and Ian makes off with the Declaration of Independence—all hope feels lost. To add to it, Ian reveals that he's kidnapped Ben's father and threatens to take further action if Ben doesn't help solve the final clues and lead Ian to the treasure.

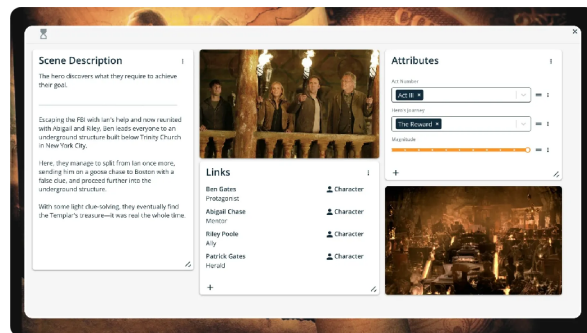
Ben escapes the FBI with Ian's help, reunites with Abigail and Riley, and leads

City. Here, they manage to split from Ian once more, sending him on a goose chase to Boston with a false clue, and proceed further into the underground structure.

Though they haven't found the treasure just yet, being this far into the hunt proves to Ben's father, Patrick, that it's real enough. The two men share an emotional moment that validates what their family has been trying to do for generations.

Step 9. Reward

This is it, the moment the hero has been waiting for. They've survived "death," weathered the crisis of The Ordeal, and earned the Reward for which they went on this journey.



An event card in Campfire's Timeline Module showing The Reward step of the Hero's Journey in *National Treasure* (2004, ©Walt Disney Motion Picture Studios).

Now, free of Ian's clutches and with some light clue-solving, Ben, Abigail, Riley, and Patrick keep progressing through the underground structure and eventually find the Templar's treasure—it's real and more massive than they could have imagined. Everyone revels in their

Act Three: Return

Step 10. The Road Back

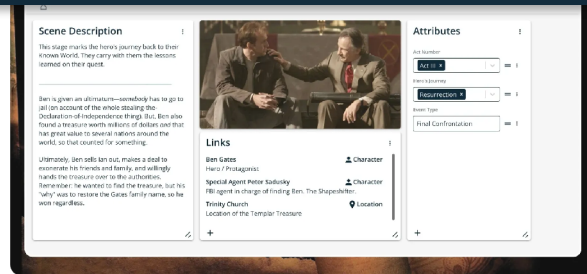
It's time for the journey to head towards its conclusion. The hero begins their return to the Known World and may face unexpected challenges. Whatever happens, the "why" remains paramount here (i.e. why the hero ultimately chose to embark on their journey).

This step marks a final turning point where they'll have to take action or make a decision to keep moving forward and be "reborn" back into the Known World.

Act Three of *National Treasure* is admittedly quite short. After finding the treasure, Ben and co. emerge from underground to face the FBI once more. Not much of a road to travel back here so much as a tunnel to scale in a crypt.

Step 11. Resurrection

The hero faces their ultimate challenge and emerges victorious, but forever changed. This step often requires a sacrifice of some sort, and having stepped into the role of The Hero™, they *must* answer to this.



An event card in Campfire's Timeline Module showing the Resurrection step of the Hero's Journey in *National Treasure* (2004, ©Walt Disney Motion Picture Studios).

Ben is given an ultimatum—*somebody* has to go to jail (on account of the whole stealing-the-Declaration-of-Independence thing). But, Ben also found a treasure worth millions of dollars *and* that has great value to several nations around the world, so that counts for something.

Ultimately, Ben sells Ian out, makes a deal to exonerate his friends and family, and willingly hands the treasure over to the authorities. Remember: he wanted to find the treasure, but his "why" was to restore the Gates family name, so he won regardless.

Step 12. Return With the Elixir

Finally, the hero returns home as a new version of themselves, the elixir is shared amongst the people, and the journey is completed full circle.

The elixir, like many other elements of the hero's journey, can be literal or figurative. It can be a tangible thing, such as an actual elixir meant for some specific purpose, or it could be represented by an abstract concept such as hope, wisdom, or love.

have an effect external to the story—meaning that it could be something meant to affect the audience and/or increase their awareness of the world.

In the final scene of *National Treasure*, we see Ben and Abigail walking the grounds of a massive estate. Riley pulls up in a fancy sports car and comments on how they could have gotten more money. They all chat about attending a museum exhibit in Cairo (Egypt).

In one scene, we're given a lot of closure: Ben and co. received a hefty payout for finding the treasure, Ben and Abigail are a couple now, and the treasure was rightfully spread to those it benefitted most—in this case, countries who were able to reunite with significant pieces of their history. Everyone's happy, none of them went to jail despite the serious crimes committed, and they're all a whole lot wealthier. Oh, Hollywood.

Variations of the Hero's Journey

Plot structure is important, but you don't need to follow it exactly; and, in fact, your story probably won't. Your version of the Hero's Journey might require more or fewer steps, or you might simply go off the beaten path for a few steps—and that's okay!



Compare the Hero's Journey as outlined by Vogler (pictured above) to the variations below!

What follows are three additional versions of the Hero's Journey, which you may be more familiar with than Vogler's version presented above.

Dan Harmon's Story Circle (or, The Eight-Step Hero's Journey)

Screenwriter Dan Harmon has riffed on the Hero's Journey by creating a more compact version, [the Story Circle](#)—and it works especially well for shorter-format stories such as television episodes, which happens to be what Harmon writes.

The Story Circle comprises eight simple steps with a heavy emphasis on the hero's character arc:

1. The hero is in a zone of comfort...
2. But they want something.
3. They enter an unfamiliar situation...
4. And adapt to it by facing trials.
5. They get what they want...
6. But they pay a heavy price for it.
7. They return to their familiar situation...
8. Having changed.

in four pairs, simplifying the core of the Hero's Journey even further:

- The hero is in a zone of comfort, but they want something.
- They enter an unfamiliar situation and have to adapt via new trials.
- They get what they want, but they pay a price for it.
- They return to their zone of comfort, forever changed.

If you're writing shorter fiction, such as a short story or novella, definitely check out the Story Circle. It's the Hero's Journey minus all the extraneous bells & whistles.

Ten-Step Hero's Journey

The ten-step Hero's Journey is similar to the twelve-step version we presented above. It includes most of the same steps *except for* Refusal of the Call and Meeting the Mentor, arguing that these steps aren't as essential to include; and, it moves Crossing the Threshold to the end of Act One and Reward to the end of Act Two.

Act One

1. The Ordinary World
2. The Call to Adventure
3. Crossing the Threshold

Act Two

4. Tests, Allies, Enemies
5. Approach the Innermost Cave
6. The Ordeal

Act Three

8. The Road Back
9. Resurrection
10. Return with Elixir

We've previously written about the ten-step hero's journey in a series of essays separated by act: [Act One](#) (with a prologue), [Act Two](#), and [Act Three](#).

Twelve-Step Hero's Journey: Version Two

Again, the second version of the twelve-step hero's journey is very similar to the one above, save for a few changes, including in which story act certain steps appear.

This version skips The Ordinary World exposition and starts right at The Call to Adventure; then, the story ends with two new steps in place of Return With Elixir: The Return and The Freedom to Live.

Act One

1. The Call to Adventure
2. The Refusal of the Call
3. Meeting the Mentor
4. Crossing the Threshold

Act Two

5. Test, Allies, Enemies
6. Approaching the Innermost Cave
7. The Ordeal
8. The Reward

9. The Road Back
10. The Resurrection
11. The Return*
12. The Freedom to Live*

In the final act of this version, there is more of a focus on an internal transformation for the hero. They experience a metamorphosis on their journey back to the Known World, return home changed, and go on to live a new life, uninhibited.

Seventeen-Step Hero's Journey

Finally, the granddaddy of heroic journeys: the seventeen-step Hero's Journey. This version includes a slew of extra steps your hero might face out in the expanse.

Act One

1. The Call to Adventure
2. Refusal of the Call
3. Supernatural Aid (aka Meeting the Mentor)
4. Crossing the Threshold
5. Belly of the Whale*: This added stage marks the hero's immediate descent into danger once they've crossed the threshold.

Act Two

6. Road of Trials (...with Allies, Tests, and Enemies)
7. Meeting with the Goddess/God*: In this stage, the hero meets with a new advisor or powerful figure, who

forward.

8. Woman as Temptress (or simply, Temptation)*: Here, the hero is tempted, against their better judgment, to question themselves and their reason for being on the journey. They may feel insecure about something specific or have an exposed weakness that momentarily holds them back.
9. Atonement with the Father (or, Catharthis)*: The hero faces their Temptation and moves beyond it, shedding free from all that holds them back.
10. Apotheosis (aka The Ordeal)
11. The Ultimate Boon (aka the Reward)

Act Three

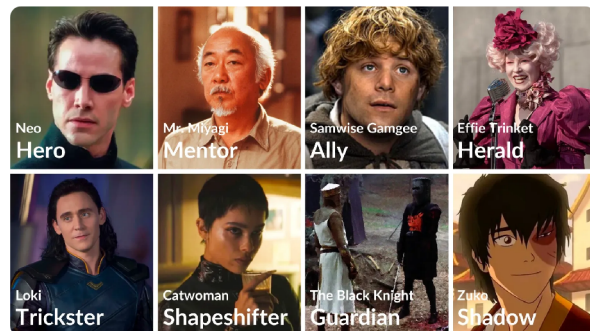
12. Refusal of the Return*: The hero wonders if they even want to go back to their old life now that they've been forever changed.
13. The Magic Flight*: Having decided to return to the Known World, the hero needs to actually find a way back.
14. Rescue From Without*: Allies may come to the hero's rescue, helping them escape this bold, new world and return home.
15. Crossing of the Return Threshold (aka The Return)
16. Master of Two Worlds*: Very closely resembling The Resurrection stage in other variations, this stage signifies that the hero is quite literally a master of two worlds—

17. Freedom to Live

Again, we skip the Ordinary World opening here. Additionally, Acts Two and Three look pretty different from what we've seen so far, although, the bones of the Hero's Journey structure remain.

The Eight Hero's Journey Archetypes

The Hero is, understandably, the cornerstone of the Hero's Journey, but they're just one of eight key archetypes that make up this narrative framework.



The eight Hero's Journey archetypes matched with characters from popular television & films. Images: ©Warner Bros. / Columbia Pictures / New Line Cinema / Lionsgate / Marvel Studios / EMI Films / Nickelodeon Animation Studio.

In *The Writer's Journey*, Vogler outlined *seven* of these archetypes, only excluding the Ally, which we've included below. Here's a breakdown of all eight with examples:

1. The Hero

or journey. The challenges they overcome represent universal human struggles and triumphs.

Vogler assigned a "primary function" to each archetype—helpful for establishing their role in a story. The Hero's primary function is "to service and sacrifice."

Example: [Neo](#) from *The Matrix*, who evolves from a regular individual into the prophesied savior of humanity.

2. The Mentor

A wise guide offering knowledge, tools, and advice, Mentors help the Hero navigate the journey and discover their potential. Their primary function is "to guide."

Example: [Mr. Miyagi](#) from *The Karate Kid* imparts not only martial arts skills but invaluable life lessons to Daniel.

3. The Ally

Companions who support the Hero, Allies provide assistance, friendship, and moral support throughout the journey. They may also become a friends-to-lovers romantic partner.

Not included in Vogler's list is the Ally, though we'd argue they are essential nonetheless. Let's say their primary function is "to aid and support."

Example: [Samwise Gamgee](#) from *Lord of the Rings*, a loyal friend and steadfast supporter of Frodo.

The Herald acts as a catalyst to initiate the Hero's Journey, often presenting a challenge or calling the hero to adventure. Their primary function is "to warn or challenge."

Example: [Effie Trinket](#) from *The Hunger Games*, whose selection at the Reaping sets Katniss's journey into motion.

5. The Trickster

A character who brings humor and unpredictability, challenges conventions, and offers alternative perspectives or solutions. Their primary function is "to disrupt."

Example: [Loki](#) from Norse mythology exemplifies the trickster, with his cunning and chaotic influence.

6. The Shapeshifter

Ambiguous figures whose allegiance and intentions are uncertain. They may be a friend one moment and a foe the next. Their primary function is "to question and deceive."

Example: [Catwoman](#) from the *Batman* universe often blurs the line between ally and adversary, slinking between both roles with glee.

7. The Guardian

Protectors of important thresholds, Guardians challenge or test the Hero, serving as obstacles to overcome or

Example: [The Black Knight](#) in *Monty Python and the Holy Grail* literally bellows “None shall pass!”—a quintessential ([but not very effective](#)) Guardian.

8. The Shadow

Represents the Hero's inner conflict or an antagonist, often embodying the darker aspects of the hero or their opposition. Their primary function is "to destroy."

Example: [Zuko](#) from *Avatar: The Last Airbender*; initially an adversary, his journey parallels the Hero's path of transformation.

While your story does not have to use all of the archetypes, they *can* help you develop your characters and visualize how they interact with one another—especially the Hero.

For example, take your hero and place them in the center of a blank worksheet, then write down your other major characters in a circle around them and determine who best fits into which archetype. Who challenges your hero? Who tricks them? Who guides them? And so on...

Table of Contents

- What is the Hero's Journey?
- Twelve Steps of the Hero's Journey
- Act One: Departure
- **Act Two: Initiation**
- Act Three: Return
- Variations of the Hero's Journey
- The Eight Hero's Journey Archetypes

Stories that Use the Hero's Journey

Not a fan of saving the Declaration of Independence? Check out these alternative examples of the Hero's Journey to get inspired:

- Will the Hero's Journey Work For You?
- Hero's Journey Campfire Template
- Lessons From the Hero's Journey



The Campfire Team

campfire

We're here to help writers imagine, plan, and tell their stories. We started in 2018, and have been working to help you write better stories faster since then. We're thrilled to have you here with us, whether you're just browsing the blog, checking out the community's work in Explore, or creating your own stories in Campfire.

[View Profile](#)

Mesopotamian epic poem thought to be one of the earliest examples of the Hero's Journey (and one of the oldest recorded stories).

- **The Lion King (1994):** Simba's exile and return depict a tale of growth, responsibility, and reclaiming his rightful place as king.
- **The Alchemist by Paolo Coelho:** Santiago's quest for treasure transforms into a journey of self-discovery and personal enlightenment.
- **Coraline by Neil Gaiman:** A young girl's adventure in a parallel world teaches her about courage, family, and appreciating her own reality.
- **Kung Fu Panda (2008):** Po's transformation from a clumsy panda to a skilled warrior perfectly exemplifies the Hero's Journey. *Skadoosh!*

The Hero's Journey is so generalized that it's ubiquitous. You can plop the plot of just about any quest-style narrative into its framework and say that the story follows the Hero's Journey. Try it out for yourself as an exercise in getting familiar with the method.

Will the Hero's Journey Work For You?

As renowned as it is, the Hero's Journey works best for the kinds of tales that inspired it: mythic stories.

Writers of speculative fiction may gravitate towards this method over

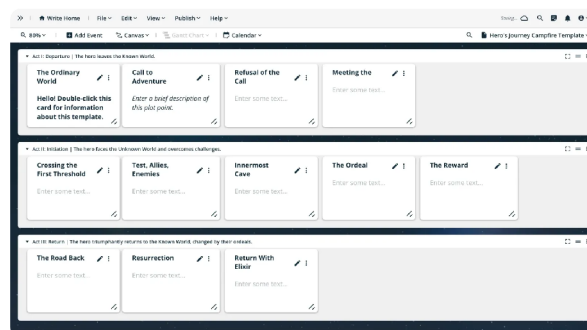
fantasy quests and grand space operas come to mind).

The stories we tell today are vast and varied, and they stretch far beyond the dealings of deities, saving kingdoms, or acquiring some fabled "elixir." While that may have worked for Gilgamesh a few thousand years ago, it's not always representative of our lived experiences here and now.

If you decide to give the Hero's Journey a go, we encourage you to make it your own! The pieces of your plot don't have to neatly fit into the structure, but you can certainly make a strong start on mapping out your story.

Hero's Journey Campfire Template

The [Timeline Module in Campfire](#) offers a versatile canvas to plot out each basic component of your story while featuring nested "notebooks."



A blank Hero's Journey template in Campfire's Timeline Module.

Simply double-click on each event card in your timeline to open up a canvas specific to that card. This allows you to look at

element as needed!



Hero's Journey Campfire Template

Find a **template for the Hero's Journey story structure** in Campfire's Timeline Module.

To load a template in your project, click the **View** tab while in the Timeline Module, select "Manage Templates," then select from the options available.

Templates are editable, so once you load it, make it your own! See our dedicated tutorial to learn more about [how to use the Timeline Module](#).

If you're just hearing about Campfire for the first time, it's free to sign up—forever! Let's plot the most epic of hero's journeys



Let The Journey Begin

Lessons From the Hero's Journey

The Hero's Journey offers a powerful framework for creating stories centered around growth, adventure, and transformation.

If you want to develop compelling characters, spin out engaging plots, and write books that express themes of valor

hero, and start writing!

Does your story mirror the Hero's Journey? Let us know in the comments below.



Write

Writing Apps
Word Processor
Worldbuilding Tools
Character Creator
Story Planner
Interactive Maps
Software Pricing
Gift Campfire

Read

Reading App
Browse Books
Book Pricing

Publish

Publish Your Work
Self-Publishing Terms
Content Guidelines

Learn

Latest Posts
Popular Posts
News & Updates
Interviews
Genres & Tropes
Submit a Post

Help

Writing Tutorials
Publishing Tutorials
Reading Tutorials
Report a Bug
FAQ

Contact

About Us
Campfire Publishing

[Privacy Policy](#) | [Terms & Conditions](#) | [Careers](#) |

©2018-2024 Campfire Technology LLC. All Rights Reserved

